

Priyanka Verma

PH.D. CANDIDATE, UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO

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Human Centered Designer (HCD) with 5+ years experience researching, designing, and deploying end-to-end technical systems in high-stakes domains, including financial services. Deep expertise in co-design, product design, and systems thinking. Design research has been featured in both academic and public-facing international platforms, translated to digital platform used by thousands of users, and presented as actionable recommendations to senior leaders at banks and housing-cooperatives.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Candidate, Human Computer Interaction

2022 - 2026

UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO, CANADA

- **Methods:** Ethnography, co-design with diverse stakeholders, human-centered design thinking, surveys, prototyping, interviews, literature review, descriptive and inferential statistics, full-stack software development, Algorithmic Fairness
- Dissertation focused on designing and evaluating AI/ algorithmic systems for rent pricing in housing organizations, addressing complex needs of diverse stakeholders
- Technical AI Safety Fellow at University of Toronto- held at Trajectory Labs (Spring 26)

M.Sc. (Hons.) Economics and B.E. (Hons.) Computer Science

2016- 2021

BIRLA INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY AND SCIENCE (BITS), PILANI, INDIA

- Special Auditing Student at Hiroshima University, Japan under Sakura Science Exchange Program
- 1 of 10 fellows at Global Talent Attraction Program (GTAP), Indiana University Bloomington, USA

WORK EXPERIENCE

Course Instructor, University of Toronto

Summer '25

MISSISSAUGA, ONTARIO

- **Taught design methods course** 'Understanding Users' to senior undergraduate students
- Conceptualized new modules, assignments to critically analyse role of AI in UX research and practice
- Organized a guest lecture from a senior design strategist at Wells Fargo

Lead Experience Designer & Developer, Microsoft Research

Feb- June '21

DR. BILL THIES

[Thesis] [Demo]

- Developed WhatsApp-based chat platform for low-literate rural communities for citizen journalism
- Iteratively designed interaction flows balancing user needs, resource constraints, fieldworkers' workflows
- Full-stack development involving legacy server, website, content moderation interface, APIs, database
- Implemented custom features to submit, share and filter audio-, video-, image-based journalism posts
- Successful adoption of system with 1000+ reports from users; continued usage at partner NGO

HCD Researcher, Indiana University Bloomington, USA

Aug '20- Jan '21

- Surveyed 200+ participants online to investigate privacy aspects of smartphone notifications
- Conducted mixed-method analysis (non-parametric statistical tests, thematic analysis, visualizations)
- Published paper and recommended design features in smartphone UIs to prevent privacy violations

Software Developer, Oracle Cloud

July '21- Aug '22

BANGALORE, INDIA

- Designed and deployed solutions for the flagship organization-wide logging and monitoring agent to enhance observability and security in cloud infrastructure; e.g: .
 - developed [open-source logging output plugin](#) to support Debian OS

AWARDS

- 1 of 15 Schwartz Reisman Institute for Technology and Society (SRI) Graduate Fellow 2025-26
- 1 of 4 recipients of the Inclusive Excellence Research Grant by the Faculty of Information (2025)
- Sustainable Development Goals@UofT Student Award (2024)
- School of Cities Graduate Research Fellowship (2023- 2024)
- Munk School of Public Policy, Graduate Student Awards (2024)
- Talent Bursary to present at Upper Bound Conference, Alberta Machine Intelligence Institute (AMII) (2023)

THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

- **Inclusive FinTech research** featured in ACM showcase- world's largest open library- for impact beyond academia
- **Presented fintech design research** to senior leaders, product designers, strategists at Equitable Bank | 2025
- Hosted a **Q&A** with award-winning AI professionals at "Responsible AI in Workplace" event at UofT | 2024
- Translated AI safety research into an info-graphic for public dissemination to 10k+ users on **LinkedIn** | 2025
- Authored **opinion article** to advocate for research-backed sustainability initiatives at *The Varsity* student newspaper
- Co-organized a 'Participatory Budgeting Research Agenda Co-creation' workshop session with govt. practitioners, researchers, community organizers at the PBP Learning Exchange held at New Jersey City | 2025
- Panelist 'Sustainable Tech Design & Cooperatives' at ACM COMPASS- global forum inspired by UN SDGs | 2025

SELECT PUBLICATIONS

Full list: [Google Scholar](#). *Some of the top publication venues are NeurIPS, CHI, and CSCW.*

PEER REVIEWED ARTICLES

- W1 Priyanka Verma** and Balagopal Unnikrishnan. When AI Democratizes Exploitation: LLM-Assisted Strategic Manipulation of Fair Rent Division Algorithms. arXiv:2511.14722. NeurIPS 2025 workshop on Algorithmic Collective Action, 6 pages (NeurIPS)
- C2 Priyanka Verma**, Christoph Becker, and Samar Sabie. 2025. 17 Years of Fintech for Financial Inclusion: A Systematic Review and Critical Value Analysis. ACM Conference On Computer-Supported Cooperative Work And Social Computing, 33 pages (ACM CSCW)
- C1 Priyanka Verma**, Mohammad R. Rifat, Samar Sabie. 2025. Maintenance, Cooperation, and Sustainability: Unpacking the Data Practices of Housing Cooperatives. ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 16 pages (ACM CHI)

IN PROGRESS

- C3 Priyanka Verma**, Awais Khan, Enzo Fouquet, Ayla Khan, and Samar Sabie. 2026. Lessons from a Participatory Design Positionality Toolkit: From Self-Reflection to Collective Imagination in a Housing Cooperative. Submitted to 2026 ACM Conference on Designing Interactive Systems. 23 pages (DIS)

LIGHTLY REVIEWED ARTICLES

- W3 Priyanka Verma** Digital Transformation and Financial Inclusion. 2025. Proceedings of Extended Abstracts from Digital Futures Symposium at DeGroote School of Business, McMaster University ([DOI](#))
- W2 Priyanka Verma**. Designing Social and Collaborative Fintech: Insights from a Housing Cooperative. CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems Workshop 2025 ([DOI](#))

TECHNICAL SKILLS

ML/ AI Cursor, MCP servers, Prompt Engineering, Responsible AI, Data Mining, ML, TensorFlow, Keras
Programming Python, Node.js/ Flask, R, C++, C, PHP, Ruby, HTML, CSS, JavaScript, Unix and Bash script
Tools MySQL, Git, VSCode, MATLAB, Docker, cplex, Qualtrics
Packages Pandas, Gensim, NumPy, scikit-learn, OpenCV, SciPy, Matplotlib

PROJECTS

Fairness in Credit Scoring Models

DR. SHION GUHA, UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO

2024

[\[Documentation\]](#)

- Quantitative and qualitative evaluation of credit scoring models for fairness and disparities

Bayesian Inference Analysis of Credit Card Default Payment

2023

DR. MONICA ALEXANDER, STATISTICAL SCIENCES, UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO

[\[Documentation\]](#)

- Applied Bayesian statistics frameworks in R to investigate real customers' credit card defaulting behavior

MENTORSHIP

- Spearheaded **Mentorship Program**, for 85+ prospective doctoral applicants primarily from marginalized groups
- Mentored 30+ graduates and undergraduates across different disciplines at UofT for research, technical skills

SELECT TEACHING ASSISTANTSHIPS

Spring '25 Data Modeling and Database Design

Fall '23 Fundamentals of User Experience

Spring '24 Information Systems, Service and Design

Spring '23 Introduction to Software Engineering

Spring '23 Experimental Design for Data Science

Fall '22 Programming for Data Science